interests'.[72] He also argues that Muslims already boycott Buddhist shops. Equally, the recent ban on inter-faith marriage is justified not in terms of Buddhist teachings but as a measure needed to protect the Buddhist community.

In this the 969 Movement draws inspiration from its co-religionists in Sri Lanka, who argue that violence and discrimination is legitimate as long as it has an acceptable purpose. In both cases the persecution of a different religious and ethnic community is justified if it 'protects' Buddhist culture. Thus the leaders of the 969 Movement deny responsibility for violence, even as they encourage it, since in their minds their only goal is to promote and protect Buddhism, and, as noted above, the victims are not really properly human.

Of course, in this way they can advocate the most horrendous atrocities while maintaining that they are not, in fact, advocating violent behaviour. The monks are already denying their responsibility for current events by saying they have not advocated violence, but can argue that nevertheless the violence that has occurred is acceptable.[73] An argument they often make is that if there is no intent to promote violence, say by speech, then there is no moral responsibility if that speech leads to violence.[74] This matters, because many people in Myanmar listen to what the monks say and respect their views,[75] giving their words an importance it may be hard to understand in contemporary Western society. Not least, as discussed below, extremist Buddhist movements have become major providers of basic education for many of the poor.

Even beyond the extremists of the 969 Movement, Myanmar is becoming more religiously intolerant. Pressure from extremist Buddhist groups led President Thein Sein to pass the Population Control Health Care Bill[76] which sets limits on family sizes and which critics argue will be applied only to Muslims. In 2014 an opposition politician, Hin Lin Oo, was sent to jail for criticising the 969 Movement,[77] and in early 2015 a New Zealander and two Burmese men were sentenced to thirty months' hard labour for insulting Buddhism,[78] when they created an online advert for a bar which depicted the Buddha wearing headphones.

The MaBaTha